

CALIFORNIA FIREARM VIOLENCE RESEARCH CENTER, UC DAVIS HEALTH ·  
JANUARY 2023

Concerns About Violence  
Within Social Networks

Results from the 2020 California Safety and Wellbeing Survey (CSaWS)



**1 in 5**

respondents (22%) reported  
knowing someone at perceived  
risk of hurting others or  
themselves.

**The question we asked**

We asked California adults, "Are you concerned that anyone you know might physically hurt [another person/themselves] on purpose?"

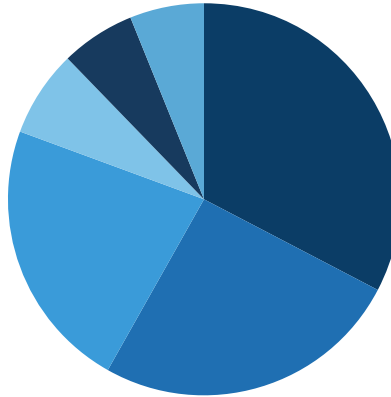
**Persons at perceived risk of other-directed violence**

How respondents described the person they were worried about.

**32% friends**

**74% male**

**26% are 40-49 years old**

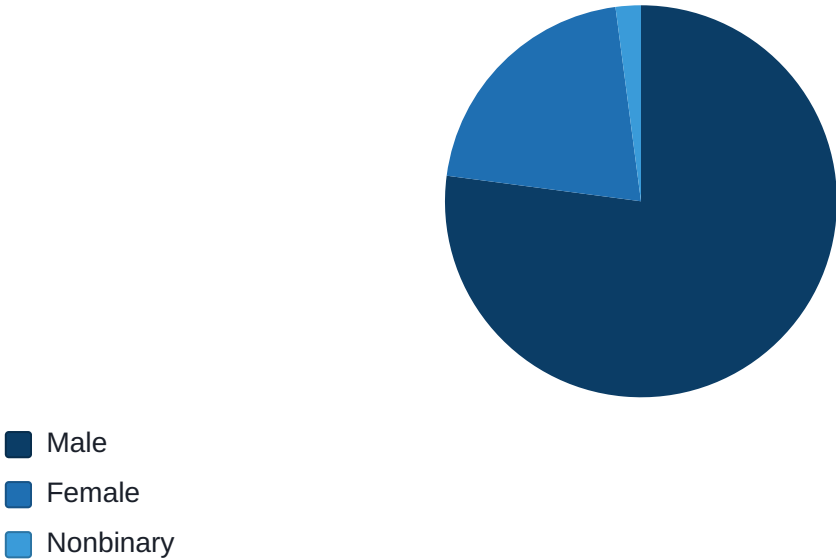
**Relationship to the respondent**

- Friend
- Neighbor, coworker, or other
- Other close family member
- Spouse or intimate partner
- Parent or stepparent
- Child or stepchild

**Relationship (other-directed violence)**

| Category                     | Percent of persons at perceived risk |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Friend                       | 32%                                  |
| Neighbor, coworker, or other | 25%                                  |
| Other close family member    | 22%                                  |
| Spouse or intimate partner   | 7%                                   |
| Parent or stepparent         | 6%                                   |
| Child or stepchild           | 6%                                   |

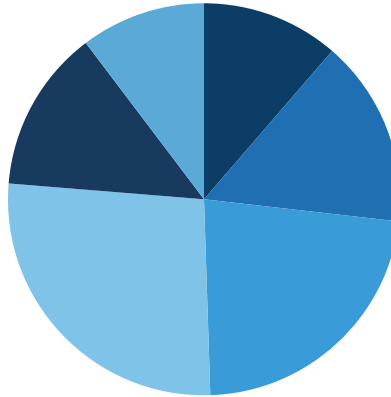
Sex or gender



Sex or gender (other-directed violence)

| Category    | Percent of persons at perceived risk |
|-------------|--------------------------------------|
| Male        | 74%                                  |
| Female      | 20%                                  |
| Nonbinary * | 2%                                   |

Age



- 0-19 years
- 20-29 years
- 30-39 years
- 40-49 years
- 50-59 years
- 60+ years

**Age (other-directed violence)**

| Category    | Percent of persons at perceived risk |
|-------------|--------------------------------------|
| 0-19 years  | 11%                                  |
| 20-29 years | 15%                                  |
| 30-39 years | 22%                                  |
| 40-49 years | 26%                                  |
| 50-59 years | 13%                                  |
| 60+ years   | 10%                                  |

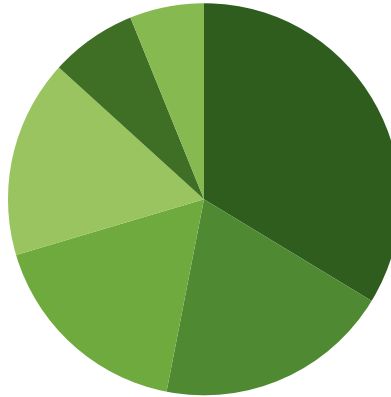
**Persons at perceived risk of self-directed violence**

How respondents described the person they were worried about.

33% friends

47% male

28% are 20-29 years old

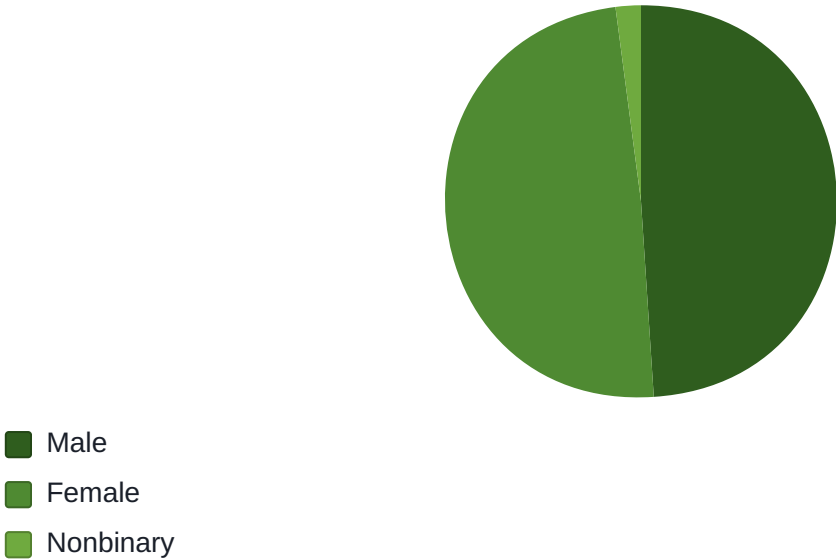
**Relationship to the respondent**

- Friend
- Other close family member
- Neighbor, coworker, or other
- Child or stepchild
- Spouse or intimate partner
- Parent or stepparent

**Relationship (self-directed violence)**

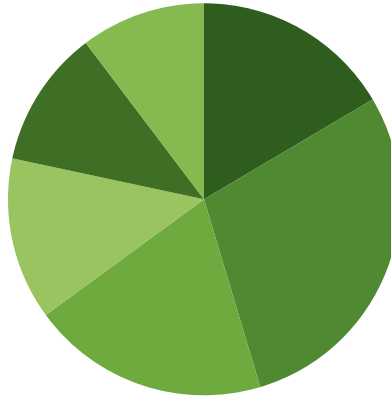
| Category                     | Percent of persons at perceived risk |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Friend                       | 33%                                  |
| Other close family member    | 19%                                  |
| Neighbor, coworker, or other | 17%                                  |
| Child or stepchild           | 16%                                  |
| Spouse or intimate partner   | 7%                                   |
| Parent or stepparent         | 6%                                   |

Sex or gender



Sex or gender (self-directed violence)

| Category    | Percent of persons at perceived risk |
|-------------|--------------------------------------|
| Male        | 47%                                  |
| Female      | 47%                                  |
| Nonbinary * | 2%                                   |

**Age**

- 0-19 years
- 20-29 years
- 30-39 years
- 40-49 years
- 50-59 years
- 60+ years

**Age (self-directed violence)**

| Category    | Percent of persons at perceived risk |
|-------------|--------------------------------------|
| 0-19 years  | 16%                                  |
| 20-29 years | 28%                                  |
| 30-39 years | 19%                                  |
| 40-49 years | 13%                                  |
| 50-59 years | 11%                                  |
| 60+ years   | 10%                                  |

\* Nonbinary includes any gender other than "male" or "female."

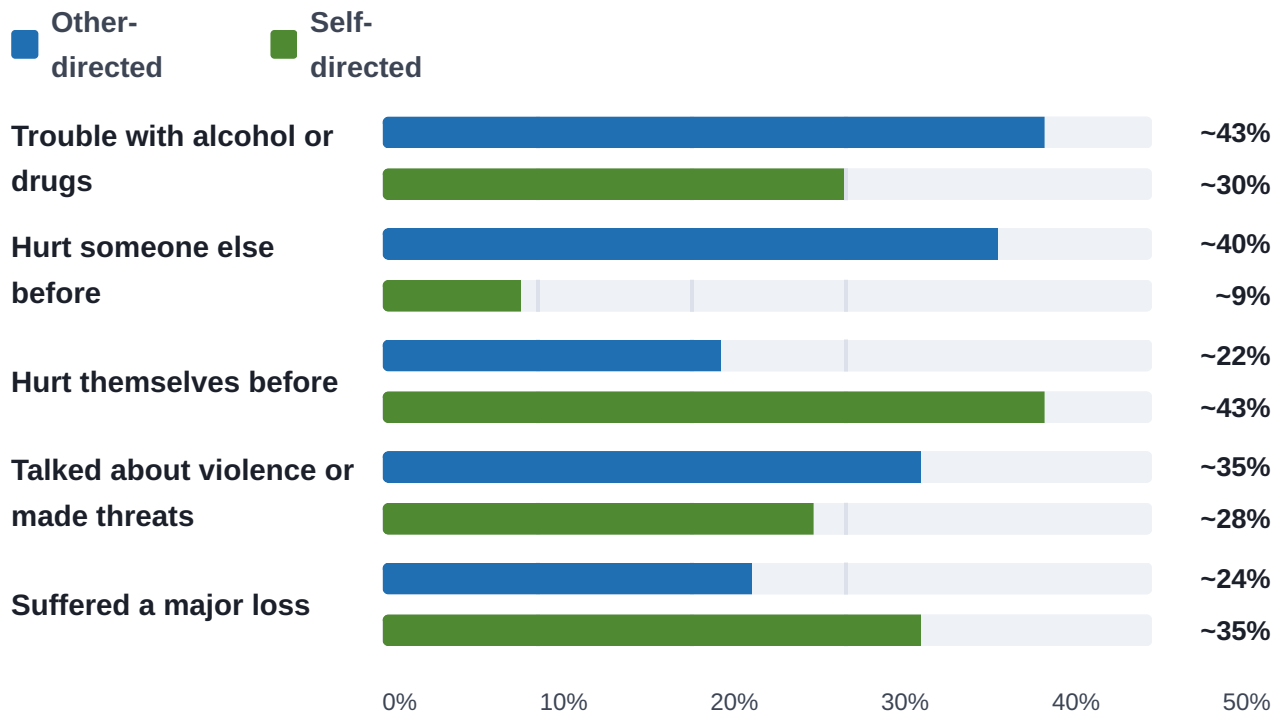
Note: Percentages may not sum to 100% due to rounding and non-responses.

## Likelihood of harm in the next year

- 27% of respondents said it was likely or very likely the person will hurt another person in the next year.
- 22% of respondents said it was likely or very likely the person will hurt themselves in the next year.

## Why respondents were concerned

Respondents were concerned about violence because the person has...



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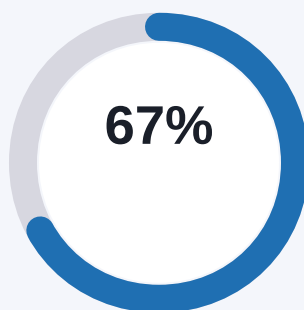
| Reason                                | Other-directed violence (approximate) | Self-directed violence (approximate) |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Trouble with alcohol or drugs         | ~43%                                  | ~30%                                 |
| Hurt someone else before              | ~40%                                  | ~9%                                  |
| Hurt themselves before                | ~22%                                  | ~43%                                 |
| Talked about violence or made threats | ~35%                                  | ~28%                                 |
| Suffered a major loss                 | ~24%                                  | ~35%                                 |

Note: The original chart plots these bars on a 0%-50% axis but prints no numeric data labels. The percentages shown here are approximate values read off that axis (rounded to the nearest few percent), not exact figures. For the exact data, see [the peer-reviewed source study \(DOI 10.1016/j.jypmed.2023.107421\)](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jypmed.2023.107421).

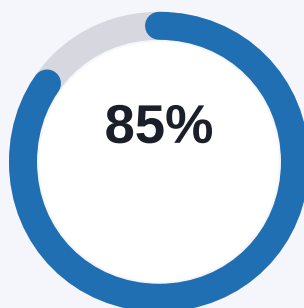
## Access to firearms

1 in 5 persons at perceived risk to others and 1 in 10 persons at perceived risk to themselves have access to firearms.

### Actions taken to reduce risk



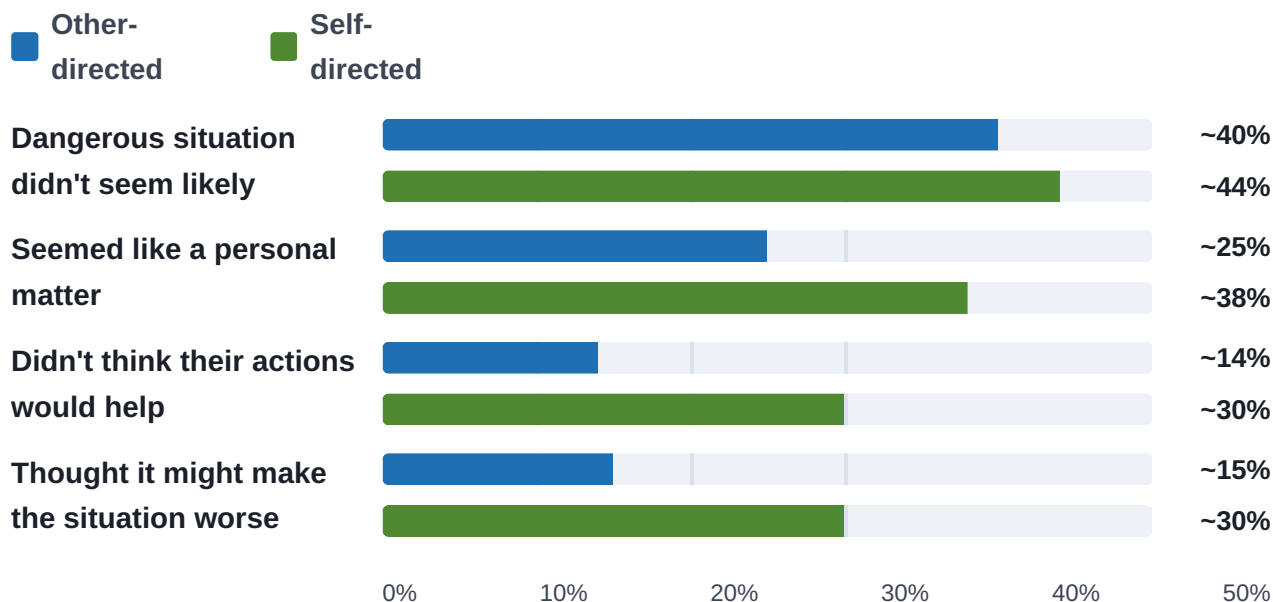
of respondents who knew someone at perceived risk of other-directed violence took one or more actions to reduce their own risk of being hurt by the person.



of respondents who knew someone at perceived risk of self-directed violence took one or more actions to reduce the risk of the person hurting themselves.

## Why some respondents did not take action

Some respondents didn't take action because...



Some respondents didn't take action because...

| Reason                                    | Other-directed violence (approximate) | Self-directed violence (approximate) |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Dangerous situation didn't seem likely    | ~40%                                  | ~44%                                 |
| Seemed like a personal matter             | ~25%                                  | ~38%                                 |
| Didn't think their actions would help     | ~14%                                  | ~30%                                 |
| Thought it might make the situation worse | ~15%                                  | ~30%                                 |

Note: The original chart plots these bars on a 0%-50% axis but prints no numeric data labels. The percentages shown here are approximate values read off that axis (rounded to the nearest few percent), not exact figures. For the exact data, see [the peer-reviewed source study \(DOI 10.1016/j.ypmed.2023.107421\)](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ypmed.2023.107421).

## What we learned

- An estimated 6.5 million Californians -- 1 in 5 adults -- are concerned someone they know, usually a friend or family member, is at risk of violence to others or themselves.
- The ability to identify when someone is behaving dangerously or exhibiting warning signs is an important component of violence prevention efforts.
- Access to firearms is common among persons at perceived risk of violence, though taking action to reduce this access was rare.
- Continued efforts to empower the public, especially those close to people at elevated risk, to act on their knowledge about risk factors for violence are needed.

## About the survey

The California Safety and Wellbeing Survey (CSaWS) is an ongoing, statewide, probability-based Internet survey developed by the California Firearm Violence Research Center and administered by the research firm Ipsos. CSaWS asks questions on a wide range of topics related to firearm ownership and exposure to violence and its consequences. More than 2,500 California adults participate in CSaWS at each wave, and their answers are weighted to be statistically representative of the adult population of the state. The 2020 wave of CSaWS was administered from July 14-27, 2020, with funding from the State of California.

## Recommended citation

Aubel AJ, Wintemute GJ, Kravitz-Wirtz N. Anticipatory concerns about violence within social networks: prevalence and implications for prevention. *Prev. Med.* 2023;167:107421.

DOI: [10.1016/j.ypmed.2023.107421](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ypmed.2023.107421) · PMID: 36641127 · [Read the full study](#)

## Disclaimer

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## About this accessible edition

This is a faithful, accessible (WCAG 2.1 AA) digital re-creation of a two-page infographic published by the California Firearm Violence Research Center at UC Davis Health. All survey figures are transcribed exactly as printed in the original. The two reasons-related bar charts in the original carry no printed data

labels, so their values are given here as approximate percentages read from the chart's 0%-50% axis and are clearly marked as approximate; the peer-reviewed source study is linked for anyone who wants to verify the exact figures. This edition is not affiliated with or endorsed by UC Davis.

**If you or someone you know is in crisis, call or text 988 (the U.S. Suicide and Crisis Lifeline), available 24/7. In an emergency, call 911. This crisis resource is added by this accessible edition and was not part of the original infographic.**

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Accessible edition generated from a single source of truth; all survey figures transcribed faithfully from the original infographic.